Oy Vey Maria

By Mark Harvey Levine

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

SUGGESTED ROLES:
ACTRESS 1: Ann, Joachim
ACTRESS 2: Mary, King 1, King 2, King 3, Little Drummer Boy

ACTRESS 2: **"And there were in the same country shepherds abiding in the fields, keeping watch over their flocks by night.**

ACTRESS 1: **And the angel said unto them, Fear not, for behold, I bring unto you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. For unto you this day is born in the City of Bethlehem, a Savior, which is Christ the Lord.**

ACTRESS 2: **And this shall be a sign unto you; you shall find the babe wrapped in swaddling clothes and lying in a manger.**

ACTRESS 1: **And suddenly there was with the angel, a multitude of the heavenly host, praising God, and saying,**

TOGETHER: **'Glory to God in the highest, and on Earth peace, good will toward men'".** *Retrieved from The Bible, King James Version, Book 42 Luke, Chapter 2, verses 8 to 14*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *That's what Christmas is all about. . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *And everything was going just fine in the manger until Mary's Jewish mother showed up.*
TOGETHER: *Oy Vey Maria by Mark Harvey Levine*

(The classic manger scene. Mary, Joseph, baby Jesus, scattered animals. The Three Kings are there, gift boxes in hand.)

KING 1: We have come seeking the one who-

(Suddenly, Ann enters. She is Mary's mother. She wears a babushka and carries a large tin foil pan of food with cellophane on it.)

ANN: Oy gevalt*! What is this? A manger? You gave birth to my grandson in a manger?

MARY: Mom! What are you doing here?

ANN: What, you couldn't find a trench to have the baby in? A manger, yet.

MARY: Mom-

ANN: What's wrong with a hospital? Who delivered the baby, a cow?

MARY: Mom-

ANN: So where is he? Where is this darling grandson of mine? *(She sees the baby and screeches with joy.)* Oh my God look at **him** he's so CUTE! I could eat him up! I will eat him up.

MARY: Mother.

ANN: I'm going to eat you up! Yes I am! Come here so I can eat you up! Um num num num.

MARY: Where's Dad?

ANN: He's still circling the block. They've got opposite side of the desert parking here. *(She hands Joseph the pan.)* Here. Make yourself useful. Go find an oven or something and heat this up. *(Joseph leaves.)*

MARY: What are you DOING here?

ANN: You think I wouldn't be here when my own baby gives birth? I'm your ***MOTHER***. Of course I'm here. Where else would I be? You'll understand when you become a mother. Oh wait, you just did. Not that I was invited.

MARY: Mom ...

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ANN: Was there not enough room in the manger? Move a few chickens over, I would have been fine.

MARY: Mom. This isn't a good time. We have company.

KING 2: Greetings! We have come to--

ANN: ***COMPANY?*** Your own mother you don't want here, but now you're entertaining?

MARY: Mom.

ANN: Me, you throw out. Them, you're putting out hors d'oeuvres? *(Joachim enters.)*

JOACHIM: You wouldn't believe the traffic out there. Must be the holidays. *(hugs Mary)* Hello, darling. How are you feeling?

MARY: I'm fine, Dad. It's good to see you.

ANN: Don't take your coat off, we have to leave!

JOACHIM: Leave? We just got here. I haven't even seen the baby yet.

ANN: He's the one in the trough. There, you've seen him.

JOACHIM: Oh there you are! Hello, cu tie! What did you name him?

MARY: Jesus.

JOACHIM: Hello, Jesus.

ANN: Jesus? I thought we agreed on Myron?

MARY: Ma, you agreed on Myron. We went with Jesus.

ANN: It doesn't even sound Jewish! Nobody's going to know he's a Jew. They'll have to remind each other when he leaves the room - "Did you know Jesus was Jewish?" "Oh, that's right."

MARY: We're not naming him Myron!

JOACHIM: Can I hold him?

ANN: No, they want him there. They left him out for the company. It makes a better picture. Personally, I'd move that sheep over a little.

MARY: Ma.

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KING 3: Um .. .is this a good time to give the gifts?

ANN: It's fine! We'll leave. We don't want to be in the way. We just shlepped three hours by camel, that's all.

MARY: You don't have to-

JOACHIM: We were gonna stay nearby but there was no room at the inn.

ANN: Can you believe it?

JOACHIM: Not one room.

ANN: And we flashed our Triple-A card.

JOACHIM: Nothing.

MARY: Look, Mom, we're just a little busy right now ...

ANN: Oh, that's right, you have ***GUESTS***. Well, if you don't want us here, you don't want us here. I understand. Promise me one day you'll describe me to the boy.

MARY: Mom, please.

ANN: Say that you turned me away, and I went home and died.

MARY: Mom, stay.

ANN: "They think it was her heart. It gave out from grief."

MARY: Stop it, Mother! Just stop! You're embarrassing me! You embarrass me all the time! You embarrass me in front of friends. You embarrass me in front of strangers. You embarrassed me in front of John the Baptist!

ANN: "John The Baptist"! I knew him when he was "John, The Kid Who Almost Drowned His Hamsters".

MARY: And now you're embarrassing me in front of my guests!

JOACHIM: Could YOU get a room at the Inn?

KING 2: We called ahead.

JOACHIM: There weren't any when we got there, that's for sure.

MARY: Dad.

JOACHIM: No rooms.

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ANN: Not one.

JOACHIM: Not for love or money.

MARY: Dad! They're three Wise Men. They've come to-

JOACHIM: The Three Weismanns? I know them. They're in carpeting. They got a store in Galilee.

MARY: No, dad, they're Wise Men. Wise Men.

KING 3: We've come to adore the child.

ANN: Well, I've come to adore the child, and I brought a brisket! *(To Mary)* Pay attention, you have to know this now. This is what Jewish mothers do. We bring food. When someone is born, when someone dies, or gets sick, or gets married. We bring food. I brought a brisket. Mrs. Bergstein is sending over a tray. *(looking around)* Who sent the loaves and fishes?

MARY: I don't know, Mom, they just showed up.

JOACHIM: *(looking at Jesus)* It's a shame his birthday is right around Hanukkah, he's gonna get robbed on his presents.

ANN: So this is your company? Three wise guys?

MARY: They're also Kings. They're three Kings.

ANN: One Jewish mother beats three Kings! Believe you me, little missy. You should know, you're one too, now.

MARY: I'm not going to be like you.

ANN: Oh ho, so smart now.

KING 1: Um, we've brought gold, frankincense and myrrh.

MARY: No! I'm not! I'm not going to drey* him around all the time.

ANN: Yes you will. It happens to all of us. All Jewish mothers. It's in the blood.

MARY: No, no, that's your mishegus*, mom. I'm going to be different!

KING 2: We'll just put them over here. *(They set down their gifts.)*

MARY: I've sworn to myself that I'm not going to turn into you.

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ANN: That's nice. That's a nice thing to say to your own mother. *(The Kings begin slowly edging out.)*

KING 3: *(whispering)* Thank you. We had a lovely time.

MARY: You drive me crazy, Mother! You drive me completely insane! You always have!

KING 1: We'll see ourselves out. *(The Kings quickly exit.)*

ANN: And you didn't? You were no bowl of olives growing up, either. I don't know how we got you through high school.

MARY: I'm not going to be laying guilt on him all the time!

ANN: Guilt is good! Believe me, this world could use a little more guilt. You read the daily scrolls, what do you see? Robbery, murder, gladiator games! If people felt a little more guilty about these things, maybe they wouldn't DO them. If everyone had a Jewish mother-

MARY: And I'm not going to nag at him all the time. I hear your voice in my head even when you're not around!

ANN: Did you hear it when you got the idea "Hey, let's have the baby in a stable"?

MARY: There was no room at the Inn, Mother!

JOACHIM: We couldn't get a room either. And we tried!

ANN: Wait a second, wait a second- do you hear what I hear?

MARY: What?

The Little Drummer Boy enters, energetically playing his drum. Ann grabs the sticks from his hands and smacks him over the head.

LITTLE DRUMMER BOY: Ow.

ANN: Are you out of your MIND? There's a baby here!

LITTLE DRUMMER BOY: Come, they told me--

ANN: I don't care who sent you! Tell them to send a basket of fruit next time! Get out of here! *(The Little Drummer Boy runs off)* What's next, a mariachi band? Vey is meer*.

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MARY: I just wanted to have a nice night. A silent night. A holy night.

ANN: When I gave birth to you, we didn't have percussionists dropping in. Everything was nice, quiet, clean. Immaculate, really.

MARY: I don't know why these things are happening! I don't know why Kings and Shepherds and small boys with snare drums are showing up! I just know that I have a little baby. And we're going to love him! We're going to love him like crazy! We're going to worship him, in fact! We're going to treat him like he's God!!! *(Pause.)*

ANN: NOW you're a Jewish Mother! Was that so hard? Welcome to the club!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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YIDDISH TERMS

* ***Oy gevalt*** is defined as oh, violence! —used to express shock or amazement.
* ***Drey*** is defined as to turn, twist, twirl, rotate
* ***Mishegas*** is defined as Insanity or craziness

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